

Kun Chen's advice for engineers in the AI era

Notes on "The 2% of Engineers Winning the AI Era (Ex-Meta L8)", A Life Engineered

Yu Jie Teo

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Kun Chen, formerly E7 at Facebook and partner level at Microsoft, interviewed by Steve on [A Life Engineered](#).

Each slide is one piece of his advice, paraphrased, with a short quote and a timestamp link to the video.

1. Kun Chen's advice for engineers in the AI era

A summary of advice from one interview, not an endorsement of every claim. Quotes are short and credited; everything else is paraphrase.

01

Keep growing

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2. Keep growing

KEEP GROWING

Test your growth every month, not every review

- Ask what you can do this month that you could not do last month.
- Waiting for a missed promotion to notice you have stalled is a lagging signal.
- As tools change faster, shorten the interval further.

Kun Chen

"What did I do this month that I couldn't do last month?" ([0:30](#), [2:00](#))

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3. Test your growth every month, not every review

KEEP GROWING

When the work gets comfortable, move

- Bored, or no longer learning; change team, company or role.
- Each of his moves, Microsoft to Facebook, news to games, engineer to manager and back, followed curiosity.
- Treat side quests as a signal that the main quest has gone stale.

Kun Chen

"Never get comfortable" with doing what you have always done. ([55:01](#), [57:31](#))

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4. When the work gets comfortable, move

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Do more than you are assigned

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5. Do more than you are assigned

DO MORE THAN YOU ARE ASSIGNED

Get the fundamentals right, then take initiative

- Being good at the assigned work is table stakes; doing it fast frees time.
- Spend that time on problems other people have: no one asked him to build the Bing click-data tool.
- If deadlines leave no slack, negotiate the expectations with your manager.

Kun Chen

"Take initiative and identify problems that other people have." ([17:01](#), [18:01](#))

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6. Get the fundamentals right, then take initiative

DO MORE THAN YOU ARE ASSIGNED

Start scrappy, control scope, ship for feedback

- Reuse existing building blocks instead of reinventing them.
- Cut scope precisely so something useful reaches people quickly.
- Show a first version to a few users and iterate on what they say.

Kun Chen

"Try not to reinvent the wheels." ([15:01](#), [16:00](#))

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7. Start scrappy, control scope, ship for feedback

DO MORE THAN YOU ARE ASSIGNED

Talk to your users before you build

- The Messenger games platform was designed around high scores and launched without asking developers.
- Retention after the holidays was poor: turn-based and real-time games did not fit.
- Asking game developers led to a redesign that gave them the flexibility.

Kun Chen

"We assumed it's going to work." ([26:01](#), [27:00](#))

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8. Talk to your users before you build

DO MORE THAN YOU ARE ASSIGNED

The title does not decide your job

- Do not hide in the engineer's corner, even as an introvert.
- He travelled to game studios and shaped product decisions; that impact made staff.
- Ask what the most impactful thing for the business is, whatever your title.

Kun Chen

"The title does not matter." ([43:00](#))

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9. The title does not decide your job

DO MORE THAN YOU ARE ASSIGNED

When things run smoothly, find the step change

- If a project would run just as well without you, you are not adding value there.
- Rethink the strategy rather than growing it incrementally.
- Chaos is where the interesting problems are.

Kun Chen

"Taking initiative step function changes." ([45:00](#), [45:31](#))

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10. When things run smoothly, find the step change

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Advice by career stage

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11. Advice by career stage

ADVICE BY CAREER STAGE

Juniors: get very good, build a hundred things

- Skill is the foundation of everything else.
- He had built about a hundred projects before his first job; most earned nothing.
- Side projects give breadth a big company's stable stack will not, and fun keeps you going.

Kun Chen

"Build a lot of them." ([51:00](#), [52:00](#))

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12. Juniors: get very good, build a hundred things

ADVICE BY CAREER STAGE

Seniors: know your leverage when you move

- At senior levels, former colleagues recruit you; that is leverage.
- The default is a lateral move, because the hiring company has every reason to offer one.
- One negotiation can be worth a level, often one you already earned.

Kun Chen

"Realizing your leverage and know to negotiate." ([58:30](#), [59:32](#))

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13. Seniors: know your leverage when you move

ADVICE BY CAREER STAGE

Management is support, not bigger scope

- Wanting bigger impact or scope is a reason to stay an IC, not to manage.
- Managing is supporting a team, recruiting and growing people.
- Going back to IC on the same team worked; no one is watching as closely as you think.

Kun Chen

"Management is really more about supporting others." ([30:31](#), [31:01](#), [39:01](#))

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14. Management is support, not bigger scope

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Working with AI

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15. Working with AI

WORKING WITH AI

The 2% are pulling ahead; act with urgency

- CTOs he spoke with see roughly 10 to 15% company-wide gains from AI.
- About 2% of engineers use it deeply and are far more productive.
- Impactful projects, and tokens, are moving to those people.

Kun Chen

"An industrial revolution happening right in front of our eyes." ([1:02:00](#), [1:03:01](#), [1:04:02](#))

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16. The 2% are pulling ahead; act with urgency

WORKING WITH AI

Treat every tool as temporary scaffold

- The tooling will keep changing until the models plateau.
- Expect to rebuild your setup every six months or sooner.
- Invest in a habit of continuous learning, not in one specific tool.

Kun Chen

"Assuming everything is just temporary scaffold." ([1:08:01](#), [1:09:02](#))

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17. Treat every tool as temporary scaffold

WORKING WITH AI

Juniors can leapfrog; seniors orchestrate

- Mastery of one language or framework is worth less now, so the gap to seniors has narrowed.
- Seniors still hold scarce skills: architecture, scaling, flaky production.
- They apply those by supervising many agents, not by coding everything themselves.

Kun Chen

"A really good opportunity to leapfrog." ([1:11:01](#), [1:13:32](#), [1:16:01](#))

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18. Juniors can leapfrog; seniors orchestrate

WORKING WITH AI

Automate your review judgement

- A senior who reviews every AI change will lose that battle.
- Turn what you look for in review into a skill or an agent.
- Ask whether PR review, built for one human checking another, should still exist.

Kun Chen

"Not carry the burden manually." ([1:20:00](#), [1:21:30](#), [1:22:00](#))

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19. Automate your review judgement

WORKING WITH AI

Learn to lose control

- Micromanaging agents' code makes you the bottleneck.
- Write down principles that steer all the agents, as a manager would.
- Move up a level: ask about testing, dogfooding and load, as an engineering manager does, without reading every line.

Kun Chen

"Learning to lose control is actually a very important skill." ([34:30](#), [1:24:30](#), [1:25:31](#))

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20. Learn to lose control

WORKING WITH AI

Takeaway

- Keep the monthly test, and move when you stop learning.
- Do the unassigned work: talk to users, ship small, chase the step change.
- With AI, invest in mindset, orchestration and judgement over any one tool.

Focus on the right problems, and bring judgement and taste to them. ([1:33:02](#))

Source: Kun Chen on [A Life Engineered](#), "The 2% of Engineers Winning the AI Era (Ex-Meta L8)".

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21. Takeaway
